



## Founding Director / Director of Operations

**Location:** Flexible, with periodic travel to urban Nigeria (around 4 months in Year 1). Must be able to take remote meetings in West African Time (GMT+1).

**Start date:** As soon as mutually agreeable

**Contract:** 1 year, high likelihood of extension. 4 month probationary period for us to get to know each other and decide mutually on roles going forwards based on performance

**Salary:** Benchmarked against senior roles in early stage impact focussed nonprofit organisations and cofounder salaries. Adjusted based on cost of living within range. **USD \$25,000 - \$55,000 per annum** depending on experience and location.

**Application:** [Apply here](#)

## About First Embrace

First Embrace is an AIM-incubated early-stage global health charity dedicated to saving as many newborn lives as possible by making WHO-recommended Kangaroo Medical Care (KMC) the practical standard of care for underweight and premature babies.

We are hiring our first core team member to co-lead our initial pilot in Kano State, Nigeria launching in late February, to help shape the organisation's impact trajectory from the ground up. Kano is the second most populous state in Nigeria, and home to its second-largest city. Nigeria has the 2nd highest number of newborn deaths globally.

**21 RCTs show that KMC reduces newborn mortality by 40% on average compared to incubators;** it has been **recommended as the standard of care for vulnerable babies by the WHO** since 2023. Despite this, it remains under-implemented at scale with coverage estimated at around 20% in Nigeria (from our scoping visit this is significantly overestimated). Our mission is to change that.

We estimate **we could counterfactually save 78 babies' lives this year for less than \$2,500 each**, rising to 585 babies each year for less than \$2,000 each if we are able to scale next year.

## The Opportunity

We are hiring a **Founding Director / Director of Operations**, a key member of the founding team. We will start working together in one of these roles based on your skills. After a few months, we and you will have a good final sense of mutual fit and organisational needs, we will decide together which exact role and responsibilities make sense to continue with, and the organisational structure from then onwards.

This is a **high-autonomy, high-responsibility role** in a pre-pilot organisation with ambitious scale and impact goals. The Founding Director / Director of Operations will **co-lead our Nigeria pilot**, owning day-to-day execution, operational decision-making, and organisational build-out, while working closely with the Co-founders (Executive director equivalent).

This role is ideal for someone excited to **own execution end-to-end**, shape systems from scratch, and play a defining role in building an organisation at the frontier of evidence-driven global health.

## Role Overview

As Founding Director / Director of Operations you will:

- Lead operational delivery of First Embrace's flagship pilot in Nigeria
- Translate strategy into concrete plans, systems, and execution
- Build operational foundations required for rapid scale and government adoption
- Act as the senior operational lead in the founding team

## Responsibilities Overview

This is a cross-cutting role integral to our leadership. Responsibilities will be mutually agreed after the first few months based on performance, mutual fit and organisational needs. Below are potential responsibilities, with leading the program expected to remain a core role.

### Program & Operations Leadership

- Co-lead the design, launch, and delivery of the Kangaroo Care pilot in Nigeria
- Oversee hospital onboarding, operational readiness, and ongoing partnerships
- Ensure hospital wards are equipped, staffed, and operating to a high standard
- Run weekly operational reviews to track progress, risks, and performance

### Execution, Learning & Iteration

- Execute and iterate on the pilot model to maximise lives saved
- Run and evaluate **micro-pilots and rapid tests** to improve implementation fidelity and effectiveness
- Translate learning into improved protocols and systems

### Systems & Scale Preparation

- Build and document **standard operating procedures** across operations, logistics, and program delivery
- Establish lean, auditable systems suitable for donor scrutiny and government partnership
- Contribute directly to the development of a **scalable implementation playbook**

## Team & Stakeholder Management

- Support recruitment, onboarding, and day-to-day management of local staff and consultants
- Coordinate closely with hospital leadership, nurses, and government counterparts
- Represent First Embrace professionally with external stakeholders in Nigeria

## Organisational Strategy

- Contribute to organisational decision-making and long-term scale strategy, with scope dependent on your eventual role.
  - In example this could involve contributing to areas such as fundraising.

## About You

You are an **impact-driven operator** who thrives in ambiguity and cares deeply about evidence, cost-effectiveness, and execution quality. You are motivated by maximising counterfactual impact and are excited to take ownership of complex problems in a fast-moving environment.

### Essential

- Strong alignment with First Embrace's mission and evidence-first approach
- Comfortable making difficult trade-offs in service of impact at scale
- Highly organised and effective in unstructured, early-stage settings
- Willingness and ability to spend at least 4 months in Year 1 in urban **Nigeria**
- Ability to work effectively in **West African Time (GMT+1)**

### Desirable

- 2+ years experience delivering programs or projects or in a leadership role
- Background in global health, development, M&E, applied research or similar
- Experience working in LMIC contexts
- Strong academic or professional track record

### Other Practicalities

- Flexible working hours, with a results-focussed culture (co-founders currently work 40–50 hours each week as a reference).
- Competitive annual leave in line with professional standards in your location.
- 1-year contract (4-month probation), with strong likelihood of extension.
- Potential pathway to greater seniority (e.g. Managing Director / Co-founder) dependent on performance, mutual fit and organisational needs. Significant scope for even greater say over decision-making.

## Hiring Process

After the initial application form, a smaller number of applicants will be invited to a series of streamlined test tasks and interviews. These are based on real work and decisions that the co-founders have had to engage with, and therefore the role itself. Each stage is designed

Scaling comprehensive WHO-endorsed neonatal care - Kangaroo Mother Care.

For a world where no baby dies a preventable death.

[firstembrace.org.uk](http://firstembrace.org.uk)

to respect candidate's time, with only a small number of candidates invited to interview. We are aiming to conclude hiring as soon as possible, within the next few months.